Zahra Mirrazi

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Research profile

I am a formal semanticist working on tense, mood, and modality, and on negation-related phenomena at the syntax–semantics interface. My research combines formal analysis with cross-linguistic evidence, in particular from Farsi, and, more recently, with experimental work. Within the DFG-funded Collaborative Research Center SFB 1629 "Negation in Language and Beyond", I investigate neg-raising and the semantics of attitude predicates (*hope*, *want*). Earlier work addresses fake tense and counterfactuality in conditionals, and the interpretation of indefinites in intensional contexts.

Research interests Formal semantics; pragmatics; syntax–semantics interface; tense, aspect, and mood; conditionals and counterfactuality; modality; attitude predicates and neg-raising; indefinites; Farsi and other Iranian languages; semantic fieldwork

Employment

2024 – present **Georg-August-Universität Göttingen** – Göttingen, Germany
Postdoctoral Researcher (DFG-funded; position held jointly with Goethe University Frankfurt), Collaborative Research Center SFB 1629 "Negation in Language and Beyond".
Project A04: "Resolving the Neg-Raising Paradox".
Principal Investigators: Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

2022 – 2024 **University of California, Los Angeles** – Los Angeles, CA
Elahé Omidyar Mir-Djalali Postdoctoral Fellow in Iranian Linguistics; Lecturer.
Mentors: Ethan Poole & Yael Sharvit

Education

2016 – 2022 **University of Massachusetts Amherst** – Amherst, MA
PhD in Linguistics
Dissertation: *Tense in Conditionals: Ins and Outs.* [lingbuzz]
Advisor: Ana Arregui (chair). Committee: Rajesh Bhatt, Maria Biezma, Seth Cable, Sabine Iatridou, Alejandro Pérez Carballo

Nov–Dec 2018 **Uppsala University** – Uppsala, Sweden
Visiting Researcher. Sponsor: Eleanor Coghill
Project: Micro-variation in aspect splits in Neo-Aramaic languages

2015 – 2016 **University of Tehran** – Tehran, Iran
PhD studies in Linguistics (not completed)

2013 – 2015 **University of Tehran** – Tehran, Iran
MA in Linguistics
Thesis: *Neg-raising in Persian.* Supervisor: Ali Darzi

2009 – 2013 **University of Tehran** – Tehran, Iran
BA in English Language and Literature

Funding, honors, and fellowships

2024 – 2028 **DFG (German Research Foundation) funding** for a full-time postdoctoral position at Georg-August-Universität Göttingen and Goethe University Frankfurt within the Collaborative Research Center SFB 1629 "Negation in Language and Beyond", Project A04 "Resolving the Neg-Raising Paradox".
Principal Investigators: Manfred Sailer & Hedde Zeijlstra

2022 – 2024 **Elahé Omidyar Mir-Djalali Postdoctoral Fellowship in Iranian Linguistics**, University of California, Los Angeles

2017 **Pre-Dissertation Summer Fellowship**, University of Massachusetts Amherst

2015 Ranked **1st of 900** candidates, Iran's Nationwide PhD Entrance Exam (Linguistics)

2013 Ranked **1st of 3,000** candidates, Iran's Nationwide MA Entrance Exam (Linguistics)

2009 Ranked **14th of 150,000+** candidates, Iran's Nationwide BA Entrance Exam (Foreign Languages)

Publications

Doctoral dissertation

2022 **Tense in Conditionals: Ins and Outs.** PhD dissertation, University of Massachusetts Amherst. [paper]

Peer-reviewed journal articles

2026 **What's in an X-marked conditional: A temporal puzzle.** with Michela Ippolito. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 44, 7 (published online 18 December 2025). [paper]

2024 **Indefinites in negated intensional contexts: An argument for world-skolemized choice functions.** *Semantics & Pragmatics* 17, article 6. [paper]

Peer-reviewed proceedings papers

Forthcoming **Existence presupposition in counterfactual conditionals: Tense or aspect?** In *Proceedings of the Amsterdam Colloquium 2026.*

Forthcoming **When does *hope* neg-raise?** with Ziling Zhu, Luisa Kalvelage & Hedde Zeijlstra. In *Proceedings of Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT) 36.*

Forthcoming **Defending a Hintikkan semantics for *want*.** In *Proceedings of Generative Linguistics in the Old World (GLOW) 48.*

2025 **Modal Past is Past: Evidence from non-SOT languages.** with Michela Ippolito. In *Proceedings of the West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL) 41.* [paper]

2025 **Choice functions & the Binder Roof Constraint.** In *Proceedings of WCCFL 41.* [paper]

2024 **From Perfectivity to Performativity in conditionals.** In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung 28.* [paper]

2023 **Missing words and missing worlds.** with Hedde Zeijlstra. In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung 27.* [paper]

2021 **Licensing by Modification: Existential readings of bare plurals in Farsi.** In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung 25*, pp. 666–683. [paper]

2021 **Functional indefinites: Skolemization as alienable possession.** In *Proceedings of the 2021 ESSLLI Student Session*, pp. 198–210. [paper]

2021 **Neg-raising without lexical excluded middle inferences: Resolving Horn clauses and other problems.** with Hedde Zeijlstra. In *Proceedings of the 23rd Seoul International Conference on Generative Grammar (SICOGG 23)*, pp. 281–291. [paper]

Book chapters

Forthcoming **Aspectual distinctions in Farsi indicative and subjunctive forms.** In *Advances in Iranian Linguistics*, Vol. 3, Current Issues in Linguistic Theory. John Benjamins. [paper]

Edited volumes

Forthcoming **Advances in Iranian Linguistics, Vol. 3.** Current Issues in Linguistic Theory. John Benjamins. With Masoud Jasbi & Vida Samiian.

Journal articles under review or revision

Under review **Presuppositions of tense and strength of counterfactuality.** *Natural Language Semantics.*

Under revision **A unified approach to neg-raising.** with Hedde Zeijlstra. (Earlier version: "A non-lexical approach to neg-raising").

Articles in preparation

In prep. **Syntactic variables and semantic minimality.** with Ethan Poole.

In prep. **Deriving truth commitments of mood from presuppositions of tense.** *Glossa.*

Other manuscripts

2019 **Micro-variation in aspect splits in nominative-accusative systems.** UMass Amherst generals paper. [paper]

Presentations

Invited talks and lectures

Nov 2026 **Semantics of attitude predicates and neg-raising.**
Syntax–Semantics Seminar (SynSem), Laboratoire de Linguistique de Nantes (LLING), Nantes Université, France.
With Setayesh Dashti, Huilei Wang, Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

Jul 2026 **Aboutness presupposition: The role of tense and mood in context anchoring.**
University of Potsdam, Germany (14 July)

Jul 2026 **Semantics of attitude predicates and neg-raising.**
Oberseminar English Linguistics, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen (7 July).
With Setayesh Dashti, Huilei Wang, Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

Dec 2025 **Neg-raising revisited: The case of *hope*.**
The Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Israel (16 December)

Nov 2025 **Syntactic variables and semantic minimality.**
Heinrich-Heine-Universität Düsseldorf, Germany (26 November).
Joint work with Ethan Poole

Nov 2025 **There's still hope.**
Oberseminar English Linguistics, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen (11 November).
With Ziling Zhu & Hedde Zeijlstra

Feb 2024 **Embedded tenses in conditionals and strength of counterfactuality.**
S-Side Story, University of Southern California, Los Angeles, CA

Sep 2023 **Embedded tenses in conditionals.** Invited speaker.
19th Workshop on Syntax, Semantics and Phonology (WoSSP 19), Nantes Université, France

Sep 2023 **Toward a unified theory of indefinites.** Invited lecturer, pre-conference classes.
WoSSP 19, Nantes Université, France

Jun 2023 **Choice functions & the Binder Roof Constraint.**
English Linguistics Oberseminar, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen, Germany

Jul 2022 **Missing modals.** With Hedde Zeijlstra (presented by H. Zeijlstra).
Workshop on Modality, Crete Summer School of Linguistics (Creteling)

Jun 2022 **Missing words and missing worlds.** With Hedde Zeijlstra (presented by H. Zeijlstra).
HU Workshop on "Multiple Modality", Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin

Feb 2022 **Cross-linguistic variation in the strength of counterfactuality: The role of tense.**
Iranian Linguistics Research Team, University of Arizona

Dec 2021 **Persian counterfactuals.**
Converging On Causal Ontology Analyses (COCOA), online workshop

Apr 2021 **A non-lexical approach to neg-raising.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
English Linguistics Oberseminar, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen, Germany

Mar 2021 **Modal Skolemization: Indefinites in negative contexts.**
University of Tehran, Iran

Jan 2021 **Indefinites: An argument for Skolemization with world variables.**
English Linguistics Oberseminar, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen, Germany

Jun 2018 **Farsi fake indexicals: Reconciling Kratzer (2009) and Wurmbrand (2017).** With Rodica Ivan.
University of Tehran, Iran

Jan 2018 **Structural locations and competition: The case of Persian *ra*.** With Leah Chapman.
University of Tehran, Iran

Jan 2018 **An OT analysis of geminates in Farsi.**
University of Tehran, Iran

Peer-reviewed conference and workshop presentations

Talks unless marked "poster".

Dec 2026 (upcoming) **Existence presupposition in counterfactual conditionals: Tense or aspect?** (poster)
Amsterdam Colloquium 2026 (16–18 December)

Aug 2026 **Semantics of attitude predicates and neg-raising.**
Conceptual Structure of Attitudes: Language and Cognition, workshop at ESSLLI 2026, Prague (10–14 August).
With Setayesh Dashti, Huilei Wang, Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

Jul 2026 **When does *hope* neg-raise?**
Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT) 36, University of Buenos Aires (29–31 July).
With Ziling Zhu, Luisa Kalvelage & Hedde Zeijlstra

Jun 2026 **When does *hope* neg-raise?: An experimental report on four languages.**
Experiments in Linguistic Meaning (ELM) 4, University of Pennsylvania (10–12 June).
With Ziling Zhu, Luisa Kalvelage & Hedde Zeijlstra

May 2026 **Aboutness presupposition: The role of tense and mood in context anchoring.**
SULA-TripleA 2026, University of British Columbia (12–15 May)

May 2026 **Which *hope* is a neg-raiser?**
West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL) 44, Instituto de Investigaciones Antropológicas, UNAM (6–8 May).
With Ziling Zhu, Luisa Kalvelage & Hedde Zeijlstra

Apr 2026 **When does *hope* neg-raise?: Experimental evidence and typological variation.**
Generative Linguistics in the Old World (GLOW) 48, University of Siena (21–23 April).
With Ziling Zhu, Luisa Kalvelage & Hedde Zeijlstra

Apr 2026 **Defending a Hintikkan semantics for *want*.**
GLOW 48, University of Siena (21–23 April)

Nov 2025 **There's still hope.**
International Workshop on Wanting, Wishing, Desiring, University of Strasbourg (7 November).
With Ziling Zhu, Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

Nov 2025 **Want is no longer existential.**
International Workshop on Wanting, Wishing, Desiring, University of Strasbourg (7 November).
With Hedde Zeijlstra & Manfred Sailer

May 2025 **What is mood about?**
North American Conference in Iranian Linguistics (NACIL) 4

Mar 2025 **Syntactic variables and crossover.**
Workshop "(Universal) Paradigmatic Gaps", GLOW 47.
With Ethan Poole

Mar 2025 **What is mood about?** (poster)
GLOW 47

Feb 2025 **What is mood about?**
Incontro di Grammatica Generativa (IGG) 50

Sep 2023 **From Perfectivity to Performativity in conditionals.** (poster)
Sinn und Bedeutung 28, Ruhr-Universität Bochum, Germany

Jun 2023 **From Perfectivity to Performativity in conditionals.**
TripleA 10, University of Potsdam, Germany

May 2023 **Choice functions & the Binder Roof Constraint.** (poster)
WCCFL 41, University of California, Santa Cruz

May 2023 **Modal Past is Past: Evidence from non-SOT languages.** With Michela Ippolito.
WCCFL 41, University of California, Santa Cruz

Nov 2022 **Presuppositions of tense and strength of counterfactuality.**
International Conference on Tense and Aspect in Conditionals, INALCO, Paris, France

Sep 2022 **Missing words and missing worlds.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Sinn und Bedeutung 27, Charles University, Prague, Czech Republic

Apr 2022 **Strength of counterfactuality and presuppositions of tense pronouns.**
Workshop on Typological Generalizations and Semantic Theory, GLOW 45, Queen Mary University of London, UK

Apr 2022 **Missing words and missing worlds.** (poster) With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Chicago Linguistic Society (CLS) 58

Feb 2022 **Performative conditionals.**
Commitments in Grammar and Discourse (Commit22), DGfS 2022

Jan 2022 **Neg-raising without lexical excluded middle.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2022)

Jan 2022 **Functional indefinites: Skolemization as implicit possession.**
LSA 2022

Dec 2021 **A non-lexical approach to neg-raising.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Colloque de Syntaxe et Sémantique à Paris (CSSP 2021)

Dec 2021 **Skolemization as implicit alienable possession.** (alternate talk)
CSSP 2021

Oct 2021 **Neg-raising without lexical excluded middle inferences.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Moscow HSE Pragmatics Workshop

Oct 2021 **Functional indefinites: Skolemization as implicit possession.**
Moscow HSE Pragmatics Workshop

Aug 2021 **Neg-raising without lexical excluded middle inferences in English and Farsi.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
23rd Seoul International Conference on Generative Grammar (SICOGG 23)

Aug 2021 **Skolemization as implicit alienable possession.**
ESSLLI 2021 Student Session

Jul 2021 **A non-lexical approach to neg-raising.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
Workshop on Negation, 28th International Conference on Head-Driven Phrase Structure Grammar (HPSG)

Jul 2021 **A non-lexical approach to neg-raising.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
36th Annual Conference of the Israel Association for Theoretical Linguistics (IATL 36)

May 2021 **A non-lexical approach to neg-raising.** With Hedde Zeijlstra.
12th Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science

Sep 2020 **Micro-variation in aspect splits in nominative-accusative systems.**
9th Cambridge Comparative Syntax Conference (CamCoS 9), online (Cambridge, Anglia Ruskin & Newcastle)

Sep 2020 **Licensing by Modification: Existential readings of bare plurals in Farsi.**
Sinn und Bedeutung 25, online (UCL & Queen Mary University of London)

May 2019 **Indefinites: An argument for Skolemization with world variables.**
GLOW 42, University of Oslo, Norway

May 2019 **Farsi fake indexicals & embedded T agreement: Predication matters!** With Rodica Ivan.
GLOW 42, University of Oslo, Norway

Apr 2019 **Farsi fake indexicals & embedded T agreement: Predication matters!** With Rodica Ivan.
2nd North American Conference in Iranian Linguistics (NACIL 2), University of Arizona

Jan 2019 **Farsi fake indexicals & embedded T agreement: Predication matters!** With Rodica Ivan.
Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2019), New York, NY

Jun 2018 **Farsi fake indexicals: Reconciling Kratzer (2009) and Wurmbrand (2017).** With Rodica Ivan.
5th Meeting of the Semantics of African, Asian, and Austronesian Languages (TripleA 5), University of Konstanz, Germany

Apr 2017 **Neg-raising in Persian.** With Ali Darzi.
1st North American Conference in Iranian Linguistics (NACIL 1), Stony Brook University

Apr 2017 **Structural locations and competition: The case of Persian *ra*.** With Leah Chapman.
NACIL 1, Stony Brook University

Other presentations

Oct 2023 **Resolving the Neg-Raising Paradox.** With Manfred Sailer & Hedde Zeijlstra.
Negation in Language and Beyond (SFB 1629), Goethe University Frankfurt, Germany

Dec 2017 **Neg-raising in Persian.**
Student Workshop on New England Syntax and Semantics (SNEWS) 2017, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Teaching experience

University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA)

Winter 2023, Winter 2024 **Main Instructor, LING 120B: Syntax I**

Spring 2023, Fall 2023 **Main Instructor, LING 120C: Semantics I**

NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive, and Linguistic Studies

Jan 2023 **Puzzles in Semantics**

Jul 2022 **Conditionals and Tense** (with Hedde Zeijlstra)

Jan 2022 **Missing words and missing worlds** (with Hedde Zeijlstra)

University of Massachusetts Amherst

Fall 2021 **Teaching Associate, LING 201: Introduction to Linguistic Theory**

Spring 2021 **Teaching Assistant, LING 401: Introduction to Syntax**
Instructor: Kyle Johnson

Fall 2020 **Teaching Assistant, LING 510: Introduction to Semantics**
Instructor: Vincent Homer

Summer 2020 **Teaching Assistant, LING 101: People and Their Language**
Instructor: Magda Oiry

Spring 2020 **Teaching Assistant, LING 620: Formal Semantics**
Instructor: Vincent Homer

Spring 2019 **Teaching Assistant, LING 201: Introduction to Linguistic Theory**
Instructor: Kyle Johnson

Fall 2018 **Teaching Assistant, LING 510: Introduction to Semantics**
Instructor: Vincent Homer

Spring 2018 **Teaching Assistant, LING 101: People and Their Language**
Instructor: Rajesh Bhatt

Fall 2017 **Teaching Assistant, LING 101: People and Their Language**
Instructor: Magda Oiry

University of Tehran

Summer 2018 **Instructor, Introduction to Semantics**

Summer schools

Aug 2019 **DGfS Summer School: Experimental Pragmatics – Theory, Methods, Interfaces**, Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin

Jul 2018 **2nd Crete Summer School of Linguistics**, University of Crete, Rethymno

Jul 2017 **1st Crete Summer School of Linguistics**, University of Crete, Rethymno

Jul 2015 **NY–St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition and Culture (NYI)**, Saint Petersburg State University

Academic service

Reviewing

Journals *Glossa* (2019, 2023); *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* (2023); *Syntax* (2023); *Linguistic Variation* (2023)

Book volumes John Benjamins, *Advances in Iranian Linguistics* (2019, 2023); De Gruyter Mouton, *Tense and Aspect in Counterfactuals* (2023)

Conferences Syntax and Semantics Conference in Paris (2023); Semantics and Linguistic Theory (2022, 2023, 2024); Workshop on Modality in Underdescribed Languages: Methods & Insights (2023); European Summer School in Logic, Language and Information (2021, 2022, 2024); Sinn und Bedeutung, Special Session on the Semantics of Understudied Languages and Semantic Fieldwork (2020); North American Conference in Iranian Linguistics (2020 [NACIL 2 proceedings], 2023); TripleA (2019)

Committee service

2022 – 2023 **Conference Organizing Committee**, NACIL 3, UCLA

2018 – 2019 **Committee on Equity and Inclusiveness**, Department of Linguistics, University of Massachusetts Amherst

Skills

Technical LaTeX, Python, R, Praat, PsychoPy

Languages Farsi (native); English (fluent); Arabic (intermediate)

Fieldwork Shaputnaya (Neo-Aramaic); Yalalag Zapotec

References

Ana Arregui Professor, University of Massachusetts Amherst
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Rajesh Bhatt Professor, University of Massachusetts Amherst
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Yael Sharvit Professor, University of California, Los Angeles
ysharvit@gmail.com

Hedde Zeijlstra Professor, Georg-August-Universität Göttingen
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